

Ministry Snapshot at a Glance

Pastor Billy Lo · Nordic Chinese Christian Church (NCCC) · Stockholm, Sweden

CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 · "The Evolving Chinese Church Around the Globe"

Who's speaking. 1.5-generation — born in Hong Kong, raised in Stockholm from age two, the first Christian in his family through the church he grew up in. Ordained 2014, pastoring that same home church for 23 years, now senior pastor of the Stockholm congregation. For 10–15 years he was the **only** next-generation pastor in the entire NCCC network — the one who grew up in the Nordics and pastored in the languages people actually spoke.

▪ Who Are the People? From one language to four.

- **Founding wave (40 years ago):** almost entirely Cantonese, from Hong Kong and some Taiwan, in the restaurant trade — "most of them don't have the high education... they work in the restaurant business." For a decade this made things *simpler*: adults and youth met together, all in Cantonese.
- **The 1990s shift:** mainland Chinese immigration brought Mandarin speakers — younger, more educated. **Today Mandarin speakers are the majority.** The founding Cantonese community has aged into retirement; the shared linguistic floor is gone.
- **No BNO wave.** Unlike the UK, "the government doesn't open this opportunity for the Hong Kong people." Immigration is mainly mainland students. "We are as usual very stable."

▪ The Defining Tension #1: The Language Question

No context makes this more concrete. *What do you do when no one's native language is the language you started with — and the common tongue isn't even a Chinese language?*

Cantonese gave way to a more-Swedish second generation, so the church added Swedish services. Then it **dropped Swedish for English** — "We switched." Why? "English will be more inclusive." English fluency among Nordic young people is now near-universal ("the local language is kind of neglected... people speak English too often"). So the network's cross-border tongue is **English — not Mandarin, not Cantonese.** The language has become *universal, not cultural* — which changes what "a Chinese heritage church" even means.

In Helsinki, next-gen pastor Chun Chun took the next step: not an English service but an **"international church."** "They will not say 'English.' They will say 'international' — because the goal is to reach different kinds of people." A Chinese heritage church deliberately shedding the ethnic frame for what it plants.

▪ The Defining Tension #2: One Church, Four Nations

The NCCC is **one church across four sovereign nations** — Sweden, Norway, Finland, an emerging Denmark presence — under four legal/religious regimes, six congregations, four decades of local cultures. It began from necessity: "all the churches are so small... we need to get together to support each other." Camps, youth gatherings, conferences shared across borders became a shared identity. "Being together... is natural for us."

But Billy raises the honest question of an organization at an inflection point: as each local church grows self-sufficient, **"Do we really need to stick together continually?"** He doesn't answer it. The scaffold worked so well the churches are now strong enough to question whether it's still needed.

▪ What a Healthy Church Looks Like (from the inside)

One word: **discipleship.** "Not only coming to church to be a consumer, but that you can find your gift and your calling" — even if that calling releases you *out of* the building, into another congregation or city. A church that forms people well enough to send them.

Racial shame weighs lighter here than in North America ("very seldom it's about Chinese people... they only want to work hard"). What the community carries instead is **exhaustion** — the 2026 camp theme is "Rooted in Rest." "If the brothers and sisters are always very tired, talking about discipleship and serving is difficult... But what is rest, and why are we also exhausted?"

▪ The Insight That Lands

Billy grew up in this network and is **its most lasting product.** What the NCCC has done quietly for 40 years is form people who belong to it the way you belong to family — durable beyond any program or pastor. Whether that structure fits the next 40 years is his live, honest question. After 23 years, that honesty is its own kind of health.